



CoARA Action Plan

AGH University of Krakow



Starting point

The AGH University of Krakow is a university dedicated to fundamental science and technology research, fulfilling a social mission of creating and transmitting knowledge and moral values to society. For over a century, the AGH University has been an institution contributing to societal development through research and education, ensuring the creation of technological and social innovations to solve the most pressing contemporary issues. As a research university, the AGH University strives to ensure the highest quality of scientific activities while maintaining international standards of knowledge.

In accordance with the AGH University strategy for 2022–2026, one of the University's primary goals is to create attractive working conditions, including well-defined rules and priorities of the HR policy, clearly defined scenarios for long-term career paths, enhanced opportunities for personal development within competently managed research teams, and foster international, active work environment.

Therefore, the AGH University is continuously working to improve recruitment procedures and standards for evaluating staff performance at various career stages. These efforts also strongly focus on facilitating access for groups at risk of exclusion or employees returning to academic careers. The AGH University follows evaluation and

recruitment principles set forth in its institutional documents and adheres to non-discriminatory recruitment standards and process transparency. In this regard, the AGH University has been recognised with the HR Excellence in Research Award.

It is worth noting that, currently, the AGH University staff conduct research in four fields of science: engineering and technical sciences, natural sciences, humanities, and social sciences. Under the Polish scientific evaluation system, the University is assessed in 17 scientific disciplines according to the division specified by the relevant ministerial regulation. This division was introduced following the amendment of the "Law on Higher Education and Science" (the Act) in 2019 and is based on the OECD division of scientific disciplines.

Due to the diverse nature of scientific research at the AGH University, an individual assessment system for researchers in various scientific disciplines has already been in place for several years.

In general, the development of a scientific career at the University is correlated with three main areas:

- scientific advancement,
- development of academic skills, and
- a system of regular periodic employee evaluations.



The system of scientific advancement is clearly connected with the regulations governing the attainment of doctoral and habilitation degrees, as well as the title of professor, which are recognised in the Polish system. This system directly results from the Act which outlines the relationship between the academic degree and the corresponding university job position. Simultaneously, employment at a certain position also determines the amount of funds received by state universities from subsidies awarded annually by the Minister of Higher Education.

Granting scientific degrees in Poland is based on an extensive evaluation of scientific achievements and contributions to a particular discipline and a field of study. The system allows for assessing interdisciplinary research within the same scientific field and research conducted in more than one field of science. This is a principal factor as it enables differentiation of requirements in various disciplines and individualisation of assessments based on the candidate's career path. The system is based on expert evaluation – the most crucial element being reviews prepared by experts appointed to assess the candidate's achievements. This approach allows for the individualisation of assessments based on the research area within the discipline. In each case, the review includes an evaluation of scientific achievements. Additionally, for the habilitation degree and the professor title, the review also includes an assessment of the candidate's achievements and the contribution to the advancement of science at different career stages. The guidelines in this area have been defined by the National Council for Scientific Excellence (NCSE), a national statutory body whose task is to promote the development of the scientific workforce.

The principles defined in the Act and the NCSE guidelines are implemented by individual universities, and other institutions authorised to grant scientific degrees, as outlined in university statutes and senate resolutions. Additionally, the experience gathered from several years of evaluation based on reviews and defined guidelines for writing reviews

has led to the establishment of qualitative and quantitative standards for the scientific achievements required to obtain degrees and titles in various scientific disciplines.

The AGH University Statute, in accordance with the Act, assumes conducting the procedures for granting scientific degrees in the disciplines within the discipline councils while retaining the right to award a degree by the AGH University Senate if a field of science is overly broad. The AGH University Senate has developed corresponding regulations specifying procedures for obtaining doctoral and habilitation degrees. It must be noted that in the Polish system, the procedure for obtaining the title of professor is conducted outside the university and directly by the NCSE.

A promotion to a higher position at the AGH University is possible after obtaining a higher degree or scientific title. In the case of applying for a position change from assistant to assistant professor, additional requirements are formulated for the candidate. For the position of university professor, the promotion is possible directly after obtaining the habilitation degree without additional requirements. At the same time, the lack of a habilitation degree is not an obstacle to applying for the position of a university professor, provided the requirements specified in the University's internal regulations are met. The same applies to the case of employing a foreign scientist if they are entitled to hold the position of university professor based on the regulations applicable in the country where they developed their scientific career.

In summary, the core assumptions of the scientific advancement system introduced in the legal regulations in Poland and applied at the AGH University involve an expert evaluation procedure of the candidate's achievements, diverse evaluation criteria for different fields and disciplines of science and are partially based on quantitative evaluation of scientific output, without specifying quantitative minima. The criteria focus on assessing the significance of the achievements and contributions to the

discipline, considering the diversity of scientific activities. The legal regulations also allow for the consideration of various career paths, providing, for example, the possibility of presenting achievements in the form of scientific publications or practical implementation of innovative solutions.

The second aspect of the scientific career development that was mentioned is related to periodic evaluations conducted at the AGH University.

The periodic evaluation of the AGH University staff is conducted among academic teachers. The periodic evaluation takes into account achievements in teaching, scientific research, and organisational activities. Teaching activities include the teaching load, the supervision of bachelor, engineering, master, and doctoral theses, student evaluations, and other additional teaching achievements (e.g., launching a new field of study or implementing modern teaching methods). The procedure also involves the evaluation of the teaching duties of a teacher and is conducted by students and doctoral candidates using a survey system.

As regards the scientific research activities, the evaluation considers publication activities (scientific articles and monographs), patents, and financial outcomes of projects. The evaluation of publication activities is determined based on data from the internal information system, the Database of Authors and Publications, developed by the AGH University Library. The library keeps track of scientific papers and patents and provides lists of points obtained by employees. The point allocation for all publications and patents for the evaluated period is based on the ministerial regulations. The evaluation of activities in terms of financial outcomes is determined based on data from the Centre for Project Management Support and the Centre for Cooperation and Technology Transfer at the AGH University, which provide appropriate lists to University authorities for assessment purposes.

The last area evaluated is a staff member's organisational activities, including all

activities for the University, the Faculty, and the University's socio-economic environment. The organisational activities include, among others, holding managerial positions at the University, Faculty, Discipline Council, or at other non-faculty organisational units (non-faculty units, doctoral schools, etc.), membership in the University Senate, Senate and Rectoral committees, chairing organising committees of scientific, jubilee, occasional events, or involvement in students recruitment committees. Other organisational activities may also be included in the evaluation at the request of the employee.

The AGH University Senate gives its opinion on the principles of employee evaluation along with the appropriate form templates. Employees have the right to appeal to the Rector for a review of their periodic evaluation.

As presented, the currently applicable system of professional advancement and staff evaluation takes into account many elements influencing the overall evaluation of employee activities, aligning with the CoARA initiative goals.

However, an assessment conducted within the AGH University indicated areas which require changes in the future and are directly related to the CoARA initiative, particularly:

- further development of the staff evaluation system, namely improving the evaluation criteria in individual categories and introducing an ongoing monitoring system of the scientific achievements,
- streamlining the evaluation and recruitment mechanisms, currently dispersed among numerous University units, such as the Centre for Employee Affairs, Faculties, etc.,
- developing unified standards for recruitment procedures across the entire University,
- improving mechanisms for broad access to the existing staff evaluation and recruitment guidelines.

Implementation plan for core commitments of the CoARA initiative

The AGH University staff represent a highly skilled and competent group of researchers, however they are quite diverse in terms of scientific output and engagement in University activities. The current staff evaluation system does not fully allow for the recognition of the best employees and sometimes insufficiently motivates the development of scientific interests and involvement in University operations.

To optimise the University's human resources policy, the foreseen actions will include:

- improving the staff evaluation system, including the introduction of the system for continuous monitoring of results. Firstly, a review of the procedures will be conducted, followed by a modification of the evaluation system to provide ongoing support in managing employees' professional careers. The foreseen changes will take into account the conclusions from a review of existing research methodologies and the metrics used at present. The possible modifications will particularly focus on the self-presentation of achievements in a descriptive form (e.g., portfolio), as the current evaluation system primarily focuses on three areas: scientific, didactic, and organisational achievements. This descriptive approach could allow for the presentation of a broader range of achievements and competencies beyond the standard framework. In particular, it will provide the opportunity to present activities from the economic and social aspects.

A clear emphasis will also be placed on the equal role of the two main components of the staff evaluation: scientific and teaching achievements. In addition to traditional indicators such as publications, the evaluation could include elements related to, among others, teaching, social engagement, interdisciplinary cooperation, and the application of open science practices, such as sharing research data,

preprints, or open-access publications. In this aspect, the role of expert evaluation conducted by the direct supervisor will be enhanced.

- Improving the principles of human resources policy aimed at developing the University's research and teaching potential, including refining the rules for: internal competitions and promotions, approvals for position changes or employing retired faculty members. The implementation of standardisation of documentation related to HR processes and optimisation of cooperation and information exchange procedures between central and faculty administration is also foreseen.

Activities within this area will include intensifying mechanisms for communicating evaluation criteria to interested parties, developing guidelines for faculties indicating the applicable principles of evaluation and recruitment, including the use of diverse criteria for assessing academic achievements, and informing candidates about the strengths and weaknesses of their evaluations. It is also essential to ensure that the HR processes comply with the applicable regulations and standards of the European Union, e.g., with the HR Excellence in Research Award.

- Increasing the individualisation of development paths and capabilities to consider diverse needs of staff, ensuring equal access to these paths, and encouraging continuous comprehensive learning in both professional competencies and creative non-professional interests.
- Improving procedures for preventing discrimination and inappropriate relations in the workplace environment. Enforcing rules where evaluators will not discriminate researchers based on gender, age, ethnicity, national or social origin, religion or beliefs, sexual orientation, language, disability, political opinions, or social or material status.

- Introducing advisory services on possible development paths for the AGH University staff and doctoral students. Improving employee mental health support programmes, developing a crisis assistance programme for employees, and disseminating information on available assistance opportunities.

The University's goal is also to provide significant support for personal development – of both academic teachers and non-academic staff – in line with contemporary human capital management trends.

Implementation plan for supporting commitments of the CoARA initiative

At the AGH University, the Rector's Proxy and the Rector's Committee for Human Resources Policy have been appointed to conduct tasks related to personnel policy, particularly recruitment, promotion criteria, evaluation of the university professor position applications, periodic evaluations, and the improvement of the professional qualifications of academic teachers. The actions implemented at the AGH University focus on creating optimal legal and organisational frameworks for the introduction of a modern human resources policy that supports the development of the University's priority research areas.

In 2020, a new Statute and work and remuneration regulations were adopted, which consider the reforms of science and higher education introduced by the Act. All documents primarily include requirements for conducting recruitment processes for university employees in accordance with the principles of OTM-R. The statute specifies the qualification criteria for positions corresponding to levels R1-R4 of the European Framework for Research Careers and describes the procedure and conditions for conducting competitions for positions in the academic teachers' group.

Additionally, the Rector plans to establish a committee to monitor the implementation of the University strategy, which will oversee issues related to the employee evaluation and recruitment process, as well as a team to monitor the implementation of the HRS4R

Strategy. The team will consist of representatives of academic teachers from various faculties and non-academic staff responsible for analysing and preparing organisational, legal, and informational documentation and developing procedures and practices.

As the changes are implemented, the AGH University will launch an intensive information campaign about the developed evaluation and recruitment criteria to raise employee awareness. This activity will also include developing and implementing effective procedures for disseminating information about open positions. For this purpose, a dedicated website with a compendium of knowledge and best practices will be created.

Heads of departments, deans, and members of the Senate's Committee for Science will play an essential role in increasing the scope of expert evaluation aspects. Concurrently, in the coming years, the AGH University will actively participate in the Polish Branch of CoARA activities.

The efficient operation of the University also requires good cooperation between the scientific-teaching teams of the faculties, faculty administration, and central administration. Currently, procedures are often overly bureaucratic, and deadlines for document verification and acceptance are not always met, largely due to the lack of a comprehensive electronic document circulation system that would facilitate timely and

rule-compliant task execution. The AGH University will prepare IT support for document circulation and human resources management to address these limitations.

The University is also systematically implementing an efficient process management system, which will contribute to the

improvement of employee evaluation and recruitment procedures. In this aspect, the standardisation of documentation related to personnel processes will be implemented, and the optimisation of cooperation and information exchange procedures between central and faculty administration will be carried out.

